

guide investment decisions. However, market signals are meaningless without a foundation of integrity. Measurement, reporting, and verification protocols must be credible, consistent, and enforceable. ESG frameworks must transition from aspirational declarations to regulatory compliance, anchored in disclosures that are material, comparable, and subject to scrutiny. Climate risk must be internalised within banking supervision, insurance regulation, and corporate governance standards. They are core to ensuring that the financial system is aligned with the structural risks and opportunities of a low-carbon future.

Institutional capacity remains an enduring bottleneck. National missions often falter at the point of implementation due to fragmented authority, limited fiscal autonomy, and constrained administrative bandwidth at the state and local levels. Urban governance, in particular, is misaligned with the complexity of sustainability transitions. From mobility and housing to waste and water systems, Indian cities require empowered institutions with the mandate and resources to plan, coordinate, and deliver at scale. Without this, urban sustainability will remain a project-led narrative rather than a systems-level shift.

Resource governance must also evolve. Water stress, already a critical constraint across sectors, continues to be managed reactively. Policy remains fragmented across levels, while investment flows into short-term interventions rather than long-term resilience. What is needed is a coherent national framework that integrates water efficiency, ecological restoration, climate-resilient cropping, and urban demand management. Without institutional convergence and sustained financing,

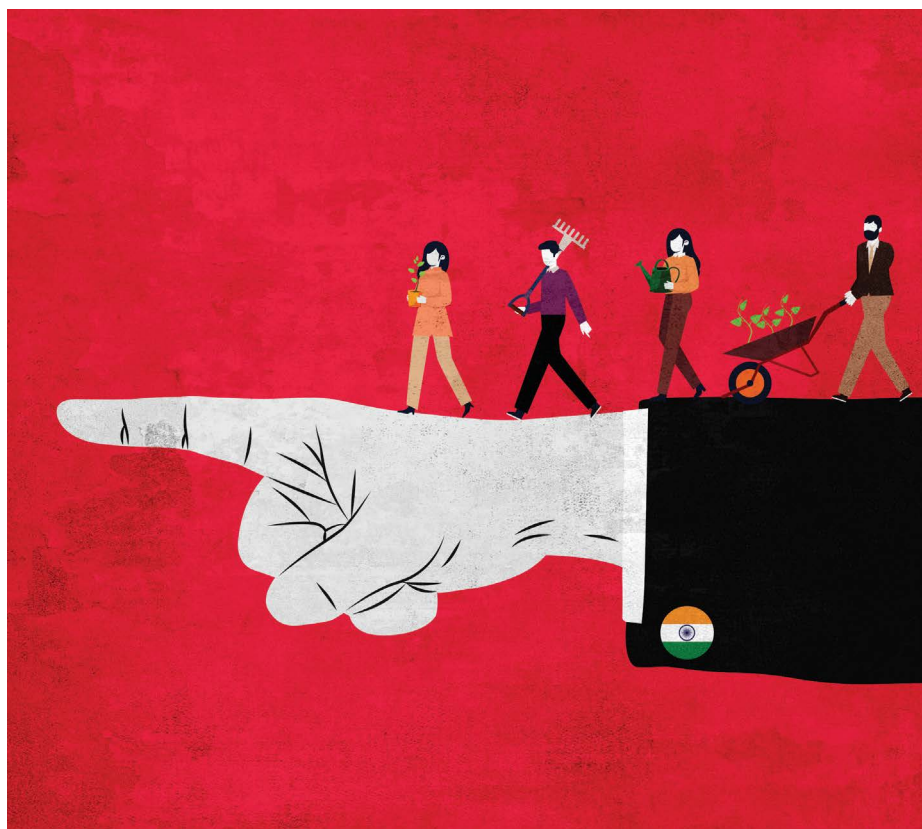


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India's sustainability efforts will remain uneven and exposed.

Leadership in this domain cannot rest on declarations or comparative benchmarks. It must be grounded in institutional coherence, policy realism, and implementation discipline. The world is entering a decade of climate disruption and geopolitical fragmentation. In that context, India's real power will not come from compliance with external targets but from internal conviction that sustainability is the sharpest expression of national interest. It secures jobs, shields lives, attracts capital, and projects credibility.

This will require coherence across ministries, deeper coordination between the Centre and states, and

a sharp focus on execution. It will require new forms of climate federalism, and a rethinking of how fiscal transfers, green incentives, and public procurement are aligned with environmental goals. It will also demand a much tighter connection between climate strategy and economic planning, especially in trade, industrial policy, and public finance.

India should build a sustainability model rooted in its own priorities, realities, and aspirations. India must move forward, not because it has been told to, but because it has every reason to. Climate is a whole-of-government, whole-of-economy mission. **BT**

Views are personal